The Care Situation Cheat Sheet

Plain words for the help around Mom, and what to write down for each.

“Informal caregiving” sounds like something other families do. It's also your sister's Thursday drive and the neighbor who brings in the mail. This sheet gives plain words for the parts of your family's care situation, and what to note under each.

The words are for describing a week. They aren't for sizing Mom up. A numbered definition comes from a public source; the rest are the Family Care Roadmap's own categories.

The picture

Care situation

How things work for Mom today: where she lives, how her week goes, and who helps with what. Every family has one, written down or not.

WRITE DOWN In a line, why the family is writing it down now.

Current arrangement

What is true today, kept apart from anything anyone thinks should change.

WRITE DOWN Where she lives, who lives with her or nearby, and the help in place.

Typical day

An ordinary day told part by part (morning, daytime, evening, overnight) instead of summed up in a word like “fine.”

WRITE DOWN What usually happens in each part, in her words where you can.

Recent change

Something in her routine, or in the help around her, that is different from before.

WRITE DOWN What changed and when. Not why, and not what it means.

The people

Caregiver

A family member, partner, friend or neighbor who helps someone living at home. That is the federal long-term care site's description, and it covers plenty of people who would never use the word. [1]

WRITE DOWN Everyone who does something for Mom, however small.

Informal caregiver

A caregiver who isn't a paid professional, usually a family member or friend. About 80 percent of care at home is provided by unpaid caregivers. [2] [1]

WRITE DOWN What each one does, how often, and roughly how long it takes.

Primary caregiver

The person who takes on most of the everyday helping. Families often don't think through who that becomes; it may start with whoever lives nearby helping with small things. [3] [4]

WRITE DOWN Whether one person does most of the helping, and who.

Point person

The one who keeps things moving and makes sure everyone understands what has been decided. In most families someone takes the role because they live nearby, are close to the parent, or simply take charge. [5]

WRITE DOWN Who keeps track of the information now: appointments, phone numbers, who said what.

Caregiving team

Everyone who is or will be part of the helping. It may include a family friend, a neighbor or a paid caregiver. [6]

WRITE DOWN A name and contact details for each, in one list.

Caregiving from a distance

Helping without living nearby. MedlinePlus counts it as caregiving, and AARP's guide says team members need not all live nearby to be of value. [2] [5]

WRITE DOWN What the out-of-town relatives do: the calls, the paperwork, the visits.

The work and the planning

Instrumental activities of daily living

The activities it takes to live independently: light housework, preparing meals, taking medication, shopping, using the telephone, managing money, taking care of pets and getting around the community. [7]

WRITE DOWN Who does each of these now: Mom, someone else, or both.

Care plan

The CDC's name for a form that puts a person's health conditions, care needs and current treatments in one place. A family's page about Mom's week is a different thing. [8]

WRITE DOWN Whether Mom or her doctor's office already has one.

Family meeting

A conversation among everyone who helps, in person or by phone. The Family Caregiver Alliance says the person at the center usually doesn't want to be left out, and that a meeting is not a one-time event. [6]

WRITE DOWN When the next conversation is, and who is setting it up.

The notes

Confirmed fact

Something written down somewhere, or said by the person who would know: an appointment card, a phone number, Mom's own account of her Tuesday.

WRITE DOWN The fact, and where it came from.

Family observation

Something a relative saw or heard, in their own words.

WRITE DOWN What was seen, who saw it and when. Leave out what it might mean.

Different accounts

Two relatives describing the same thing differently. The Family Caregiver Alliance calls it natural for siblings to take in a situation at different times and in different ways. [4]

WRITE DOWN Both versions, each with a name. Don't pick one.

Unanswered question

Something nobody in the family can say for certain yet.

WRITE DOWN “Not yet known,” and who might know. Don't fill it in with a guess.

Review date or change trigger

The date, or the kind of everyday change, that tells the family to look at the page again. The CDC suggests updating a written care plan every year, or sooner after a change in health or medicines. [8]

WRITE DOWN The date, the trigger, and where the page is kept.

What this sheet doesn't do

It gives you words. It doesn't say which of them matter for Mom, how she is managing, or whether anything should change.

Ready for the next step?

You've put plain words to the help around Mom and a note beside each one. The care interview works through the same ground a part at a time, asks about the areas nobody has mentioned, and builds a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Who Will Provide Your Care?
2. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Caregivers
3. National Institute on Aging (NIH), Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
5. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
7. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Glossary
8. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan

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From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.